

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Water

Find It. Purify It. Protect It.

Water is one of the first things we must think about in an emergency.

- How much water you need.
- Where you can find it.
- How to make questionable water safe.
- How to store clean water without contaminating it.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need water right now

1

Use stored or bottled drinking water first.

2

If the water may contain germs, boil it.

3

If you cannot boil it, use an approved disinfection method.

4

If you suspect fuel, chemicals, or other toxic contamination, find another source.

IMPORTANT

Boiling kills germs. It does not remove most chemicals.

PLANNING AMOUNT

How much water?

A good emergency starting point is:

1 gallon

PER PERSON, PER DAY

This covers drinking and some basic cooking and hygiene needs. Keep more when possible for:

- Hot weather, illness, or heavy physical activity.
- Children and older adults.
- Pets.

For home preparedness, storing several days is good. A two-week supply is even better when practical.

START WITH THE SAFEST

Where can you find water?

Possible sources include:

- Stored drinking water.
- Bottled water.
- A safe public water supply.
- A safe well.
- Household plumbing.
- An appropriate household water heater.
- Rainwater.
- Springs.
- Streams and rivers.
- Lakes and ponds.

Outdoor water should normally be treated before drinking. Clear water is not necessarily safe water.

How to boil water

Boiling is the simplest dependable method for killing most disease-causing germs.

- STEP 1

If the water is cloudy, let sediment settle or pass the water through a clean cloth or coffee filter.
- STEP 2

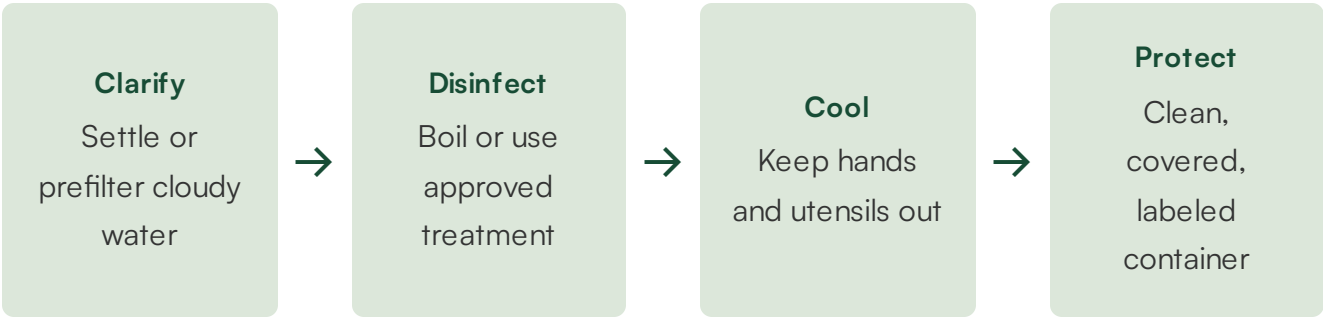
Bring the water to a rolling boil.
- STEP 3

Boil for 1 minute. At elevations above approximately 6,500 feet, boil for 3 minutes.
- STEP 4

Allow the water to cool naturally.
- STEP 5

Put it into a clean, covered container.

SAFE-WATER SEQUENCE



EMERGENCY BACKUP

If you cannot boil

Ordinary unscented household chlorine bleach can be an emergency backup. Check the label first.

For clear water and bleach containing 5%—9% sodium hypochlorite:

1 gallon + 8 drops

1. Stir well.
2. Wait at least 30 minutes.
3. Keep the treated water covered.

For cloudy, murky, colored, or very cold water, CDC guidance calls for double the amount.

NEVER USE

- Scented bleach.
- Color-safe bleach.
- Bleach mixed with cleaners.
- Products when you do not know what they contain.

Never guess. Check the label and current public-health instructions.

KNOW YOUR EQUIPMENT

What about water filters?

Filters can be extremely useful. But remember:

A filter is not automatically a purifier.

Different filters remove different things. Some remove parasites. Some remove bacteria. Many do not reliably remove viruses.

Before depending on a filter, know:

- What it removes and what it does not remove.
- How often it must be cleaned or replaced.
- Whether the water also needs to be disinfected.

Follow the manufacturer's instructions.

FIND ANOTHER SOURCE

When water cannot be made safe

Do not assume every contaminated water source can be repaired by boiling or filtering.

Water suspected of containing gasoline, fuel oil, pesticides, toxic chemicals, or industrial contamination should not simply be boiled and consumed.

Find another water source.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple water kit

☐ Stored drinking water

☐ Food-grade water containers

☐ Large cooking pot

☐ Safe heat source

☐ Clean cloth or coffee filters

☐ Portable water filter

☐ Unscented household bleach

☐ Medicine dropper

☐ Water purification tablets

☐ Buckets

☐ Funnel

☐ Labels and permanent marker

PREVENT RECONTAMINATION

The two-container rule

This one habit can prevent many problems. Keep two containers clearly marked:

CONTAINER 1

Untreated water

CONTAINER 2

Safe drinking water

Never put purified water back into a dirty container. Do not dip dirty hands, cups, or utensils into stored drinking water. A covered container with a pouring spout is best.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Assume clear water is safe.

✗ Drink directly from a stream because it looks clean.

✗ Put clean water into a dirty container.

✗ Guess at bleach amounts.

✗ Assume every camping filter removes every danger.

✗ Waste drinking water when untreated water could serve another purpose.

✗ Assume boiling removes chemicals.

TRY THIS NOW

Water practice

Take one gallon of water and pretend the normal water supply has stopped.

1. Find a way to filter visible sediment.
2. Boil the water.
3. Cool it.
4. Put it into a clean container.
5. Label it **Safe Water**.

Could I still do this if the electricity and running water were both off?

If not, you have discovered what you need to prepare.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I know how much drinking water I have.

☐ I know where additional water could come from.

☐ I can boil water without grid electricity.

☐ I have clean water containers.

☐ I know how my water filter works.

☐ I have a backup purification method.

☐ I can keep untreated water separate from safe water.

REMEMBER

Water does not have to look dirty to be dangerous.

Boiling is usually the simplest way to kill germs.

Chemical contamination requires another source.

FIND IT. PURIFY IT. PROTECT IT.

Official guidance

Emergency instructions can change. Check current local public-health advice whenever it is available.

CDC: How to Make Water Safe in an Emergency(<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>)

CDC: Create and Store an Emergency Water Supply (<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/how-to-create-and-store-an-emergency-water-supply.html>)

Ready.gov: Water(<https://www.ready.gov/water>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Fire & Heat

Warmth. Cooking. Hot Water.

Fire can become one of our most useful resources when normal power and heating systems stop working.

- Warmth.
- Hot water.
- Cooking.
- A way to boil water for purification.

CREATE HEAT WITHOUT CREATING ANOTHER EMERGENCY.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need heat right now

1

Keep people warm before trying to heat the whole building.

Use warm clothing, hats, gloves, blankets, sleeping bags, and layers.

2

Choose one smaller room or area.

It usually takes much less fuel to keep one occupied area warm than an entire building.

3

Use only heating equipment designed for the location where you are using it.

4

Maintain ventilation when required.

5

Have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

INVISIBLE DANGER

Carbon monoxide

You cannot see it.

You cannot smell it.

Carbon monoxide can cause headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, confusion, unconsciousness, and death.

If a carbon-monoxide alarm sounds or people suddenly develop these symptoms around combustion equipment, get everyone into fresh air and seek emergency assistance.

KEEP COMBUSTION OUTSIDE

Never use these indoors

✗ Charcoal or barbecue grills.

✗ Portable gasoline generators.

✗ Gasoline engines.

✗ Outdoor camp stoves not approved for indoor use.

✗ A gas oven or kitchen range used to heat a building.

20 feet

Operate a generator outdoors, at least this far from windows, doors, and vents.

Using a fireplace or wood stove

Use only equipment designed and installed for indoor heating. Before depending on it:

☐ Know that the chimney or flue is clear.

☐ Make sure the stove or fireplace is in good condition.

☐ Have a fire extinguisher nearby.

☐ Have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

☐ Keep combustible materials away from the fire.

☐ Know how to control and extinguish the fire.

Chimneys should be inspected and cleaned regularly. Blocked chimneys can allow dangerous carbon monoxide to accumulate indoors.

FUEL PREPARATION

Wood

If wood is available locally, it can provide a renewable source of emergency heat and cooking fuel. But having trees is not the same as having usable firewood.

You need a way to cut, split, move, and store it, as well as people who know how to work safely.

Basic wood tools



Bow saw or hand saw



Axe



Splitting maul



Wedges



Work gloves



Eye protection



Sharpening equipment



Tarp or covered storage

Power saws can make the work faster, but hand tools remain useful when fuel or electricity is unavailable.

Dry wood matters

Wet wood is difficult to ignite, produces less useful heat and more smoke, and can create more deposits in chimneys.

Keep dry firewood protected from rain and snow. Do not wait for an emergency to begin cutting all the wood you will need.

BUILD GRADUALLY

How to start a basic wood fire

1

Tinder

Material that catches easily:
dry paper, dry grass, fine
dry wood shavings, or
commercial fire starters.

2

Kindling

Small dry sticks and pieces
of wood.

3

Firewood

Larger pieces that burn
longer and provide heat.

Tinder → Kindling → Small Wood → Larger Wood

Do not smother a small flame by adding large logs too quickly.

You also need air

Heat + Fuel + Oxygen

If a fire repeatedly goes out, one of those three things is usually missing. Good airflow helps a fire burn efficiently, but always use indoor equipment as designed so smoke and sparks stay out of the room.

CONTROLLED HEAT

Cooking with fire

An emergency cooking system does not need to be complicated. The goal is simply to create controlled heat beneath a pot.

- A wood stove with a cooking surface.
- A properly installed cookstove.
- An outdoor rocket stove.
- An outdoor grill or safe outdoor cooking fire.

Outdoor cooking equipment stays outdoors. Never move a charcoal grill or ordinary camping stove indoors because the weather is bad.

CONNECTED SYSTEMS

Fire and water

A dependable heat source allows you to boil questionable water to kill germs. An emergency water plan should answer:

How would I boil water if the electricity and gas were both off?

A large pot and a dependable alternative heat source can be extremely valuable.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple fire & heat kit

☐ Dry firewood

☐ Matches and lighters

☐ Fire starters

☐ Hand saw

☐ Axe or splitting maul

☐ Work gloves

☐ Large cooking pot

☐ Safe heating or cooking appliance

☐ Fire extinguisher

☐ Smoke alarms

☐ Carbon-monoxide alarms

☐ Flashlights or headlamps

☐ Warm clothing

☐ Blankets or sleeping bags

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Use outdoor combustion equipment indoors.

✗ Run a generator in a house, basement, garage, or carport.

✗ Put a generator near doors or windows.

✗ Use a kitchen oven to heat the house.

✗ Burn wood in an unvented indoor space.

✗ Leave a fire unattended or allow children near an unsupervised fire.

✗ Store gasoline beside a stove or fireplace.

✗ Assume opening a window makes unsafe equipment safe.

✗ Wait until an emergency to learn how equipment works.

TRY THIS NOW

Fire & heat practice

Pick the emergency heating or cooking system you would actually depend upon. Then answer:

1. Where is it, and does it work?
2. Do I know how to operate it?
3. Where is the fuel, and how much do I have?
4. Can I safely boil a large pot of water with it?
5. Are working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms nearby?
6. Where is the fire extinguisher?

Then actually practice using the system safely.

Do not discover how it works during the emergency.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I know how I would stay warm without electricity.

☐ I have warm clothing and blankets.

☐ I have a safe alternative heat source and know how to operate it.

☐ I have fuel available.

☐ I have basic wood-cutting tools if I depend on wood.

☐ I have a way to boil water.

☐ My chimney or flue is safe.

☐ I have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

☐ I have a fire extinguisher.

REMEMBER

Warm the people before trying to warm the building.

Never bring outdoor combustion equipment indoors.

Fire needs fuel, heat, and air, but people need clean air too.

USE FIRE. RESPECT FIRE. CONTROL FIRE.

Official guidance

Follow local emergency instructions and the manufacturer's directions for every heating, cooking, or power device.

CDC: Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics(<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/about/index.html>)

CDC: Protect Yourself During a Power Outage (<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>)

U.S. Fire Administration: Heating Fire Safety(<https://www.usfa.fema.gov/downloads/pdf/publications/heating-fire-safety-handout.pdf>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Shelter

Stay Dry. Stay Safe. Hold the Temperature.

Shelter is more than having a roof over your head. A useful emergency shelter must protect you from cold, heat, wind, rain, snow, flooding, unsafe air, and structural hazards.

FIRST MAKE IT SAFE. THEN MAKE IT COMFORTABLE.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need shelter right now

1

Get away from immediate danger.

Do not remain in a building threatened by fire, flooding, collapse, gas leaks, heavy smoke, or other obvious hazards.

2

Get dry and out of the wind.

Wet clothing and wind can remove body heat surprisingly quickly.

3

Choose the safest available space.

4

Keep people together when practical.

5

Heat the people and occupied space rather than trying to heat an entire building.

CHOOSE CAREFULLY

The best part of a building

In a long power outage, some rooms will be much easier to live in than others. Look for a space that is:

- Dry.
- Structurally sound.
- Protected from wind.
- Reasonably insulated.
- Large enough for its occupants.
- Close to necessary supplies.
- Able to be safely ventilated.

Interior rooms often lose less heat than exposed rooms with many windows.

What about basements?

The surrounding earth can help moderate temperature, but a basement is only useful if it is safe.

☐ Does it flood?

☐ Is it dry and free of mold?

☐ Is there adequate ventilation?

☐ Are there safe exits?

☐ Are heating appliances properly vented?

☐ Is there a carbon-monoxide alarm?

☐ Is the structure sound?

A basement that may flood should not be considered a safe shelter during a flood emergency.

CONSERVE BODY HEAT

In cold weather

The first goal is not to make the room feel like summer. The goal is to keep people safely warm.

- Wear layers, hats, and dry socks.
- Use blankets and sleeping bags.
- Place rugs or padding beneath sleeping areas.
- Close off unused rooms when appropriate.
- Concentrate people in a smaller safe living area.

People lose heat to cold floors as well as cold air.

WARM THE PERSON BEFORE THE ROOM

Dry body layers

Base layers, dry socks, and hat

Insulating cover

Blankets or sleeping bag around the person

Floor barrier

Rugs, pads, cardboard, or other dry insulation underneath

Keep people dry

Wet clothing can become dangerous in cool weather. Hypothermia can occur even above 40°F when someone becomes chilled from rain, sweat, or immersion.

STEP 1 Get the person out of the wind.

STEP 2 Remove wet clothing when dry replacements are available.

STEP 3 Put on dry layers.

STEP 4 Wrap the person in blankets or a sleeping bag.

STEP 5 Warm the person gradually.

RECOGNIZE THE WARNING SIGNS

Watch for hypothermia

Shivering

Extreme tiredness

Confusion

Fumbling hands

Slurred speech

Drowsiness

Severe hypothermia is a medical emergency. Do not assume that a confused or unusually sleepy person is simply tired.

PEOPLE NEED CLEAN AIR

Don't seal the room too tightly

Stopping drafts can conserve heat, but people still need safe air. Be especially careful with wood stoves, fireplaces, fuel-burning heaters, and any combustion appliance.

Never block required vents or flues. Have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

Indoor combustion can produce deadly carbon monoxide, which cannot be seen or smelled.

PREVENT DANGEROUS OVERHEATING

In hot weather

- Use the coolest part of the building.
- Stay out of direct sunlight and close sun-facing shades.
- Use ventilation when outdoor conditions allow.
- Reduce unnecessary physical activity.
- Drink adequate safe water.
- Move if the building becomes dangerously hot.

Sometimes the safest shelter is somewhere else.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

Your sleeping area

An emergency sleeping space does not have to look like a bedroom. You mainly need:

- A dry location with insulation from the floor.
- Blankets, sleeping bags, and warm clothing.
- Enough space to lie down safely.
- A clear path to the exit.

Avoid blocking doors, stairs, hallways, or emergency exits.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple shelter kit

☐ Blankets

☐ Sleeping bags

☐ Warm clothing

☐ Hats and gloves

☐ Dry socks

☐ Tarps

☐ Rope or cord

☐ Plastic sheeting

☐ Duct tape

☐ Flashlights or headlamps

☐ Battery-powered lights

☐ Smoke alarms

☐ Carbon-monoxide alarms

☐ Fire extinguisher

☐ Basic hand tools

☐ First-aid kit

PROTECT, BUT DO NOT TAKE RISKS

Temporary repairs

After a storm, a tarp, plastic sheeting, rope, and basic tools may temporarily protect a damaged area from rain, snow, wind, or further water damage.

Shelter is replaceable. People are not.

Do not climb onto an unsafe roof or enter a damaged structure just to make a repair.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Stay in a building that appears structurally unsafe.

✗ Use a basement that is flooding or likely to flood.

✗ Ignore mold or serious dampness.

✗ Sleep directly on a very cold floor when insulation is available.

✗ Stay in wet clothing.

✗ Block required ventilation to save heat.

✗ Use unsafe heating equipment indoors.

✗ Block exits with beds, supplies, or furniture.

✗ Heat an entire large building when one safe room would do.

✗ Assume staying home is always safer than leaving.

TRY THIS NOW

Shelter practice

Imagine the electricity and normal heat will be off for three days. Walk through your home or building and choose the room or area you would use.

1. Is it dry and protected from wind?
2. Can everyone fit?
3. How would everyone stay warm?
4. What would people sleep on?
5. Where are the blankets?
6. Is there safe ventilation?
7. Where are the smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms?
8. Is there more than one way out?
9. What would make everyone leave the building?

If you cannot answer these questions now, you know what needs attention.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I know the safest areas of my home or building.

☐ I know whether my basement floods.

☐ I have checked for moisture and mold.

☐ I have enough blankets, sleeping bags, and warm dry clothing.

☐ I can insulate sleeping areas from a cold floor.

☐ I have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

☐ I know how I would safely heat the occupied area.

☐ I know when staying would become more dangerous than leaving.

REMEMBER

Shelter means dry, safe, and protected, not perfect comfort.

Warm the people before trying to warm the whole building.

If the shelter itself becomes dangerous, leave.

GET SAFE. STAY DRY. HOLD THE TEMPERATURE.

Official guidance

Follow current local evacuation, weather, fire, and public-health instructions during an emergency.

FEMA: Basements and Safe Rooms(<https://www.fema.gov/node/my-house-has-basement-do-i-need-safe-room>)

CDC: Preventing Hypothermia(<https://www.cdc.gov/winter-weather/prevention/index.html>)

CDC: Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics(<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/about/index.html>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Food

Store Simple Food. Use It Wisely.

In an emergency, food does not need to be perfect. It needs to nourish people, store well, be simple to prepare, conserve fuel and water, and last long enough to matter.

SIMPLE FOOD IS GOOD FOOD.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need food right now

1**Use food that will spoil first.**

Eat safely refrigerated and fresh foods before opening long-term storage.

2**Protect the food you have.**

Keep it dry, covered, away from pests and chemicals, and away from contaminated water.

3**Cook simply.**

Do not waste fuel trying to make elaborate meals.

4**Make sure everyone gets enough.**

In a real shortage, fair distribution matters.

BEGIN WITH FAMILIAR FOODS

What should you store?

Start with foods that are familiar, nutritious, long-lasting, easy to prepare, and easy to rotate into normal meals.

- Rice
- Beans and lentils
- Oats
- Pasta and flour
- Salt and cooking oil
- Canned foods
- Dried fruit
- Nuts and seeds
- Shelf-stable milk or alternatives
- Simple seasonings

Store what you already know how to eat. Do not build an emergency supply around foods no one likes or knows how to prepare.

A USEFUL FOUNDATION

Rice and beans

Rice and beans are inexpensive, easy to store, familiar, filling, and nutritious. A small amount can feed many people when combined with other basic foods.

Dry beans can require a lot of cooking fuel. Lentils and smaller beans usually cook faster. When fuel is limited, foods that cook quickly become more valuable.

Think about fuel

How much fuel will this food require?

A balanced supply gives you options:

USE NO FUEL

No-cook

Nut butters, crackers, nuts, dried fruit, and ready-to-eat canned foods.

USE LESS FUEL

Quick-cook

Lentils, oats, pasta, couscous, and quick-cooking grains.

PLAN AHEAD

Long-cook

Dry beans and whole grains.

CONSERVE DRINKING WATER

Think about water

Some foods need large amounts of water to prepare. During a shortage, that can become a problem.

- Cook with only the water you need.
- Use cooking liquid in the meal instead of discarding it.
- Avoid foods that require repeated rinsing when water is scarce.

Food should not consume the water you need for drinking.

ENERGY AND SATISFACTION

Fat, salt, and flavor matter

Include useful fats

Fats provide concentrated energy and make simple foods more satisfying. Cooking oil, nut butters, nuts, and seeds are useful sources. Rotate oils regularly because they do not store as long as dry grains and beans.

Keep simple seasonings

Salt is useful for flavor, cooking, and some food-preservation methods. Pepper, dried herbs, spices, bouillon, or seasoning mixes can make repetitive meals much easier to eat.

READY TO EAT

Canned food

Canned food is already cooked, needs little or no additional fuel, has a long shelf life, and is easy to portion. Keep a manual can opener.

DISCARD CANS THAT ARE

- Bulging or leaking.
- Badly rusted.
- Punctured or cracked.
- Severely crushed or dented.

When in doubt, discard questionable food.

DURING A POWER OUTAGE

Refrigerated food

- Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed as much as possible.
- An unopened refrigerator generally keeps food cold for about four hours.
- Use time and measured temperature to judge safety, not smell or appearance alone.
- Never taste food to determine whether it is safe.

When in doubt, throw it out.

BUILD GRADUALLY

How much food should you keep?

Plan in **person-days**. One person supplied for one day equals one person-day. Multiply the number of people by the number of days you want to cover.



Calculate your household

People × Days = **Person-days**

1 person for 3 days	3 person-days
2 people for 7 days	14 person-days
4 people for 14 days	56 person-days

Build one complete day first

Set aside one full day of realistic food for each person. Include breakfast, two simple main meals, a no-cook option, snacks, cooking fat, and seasonings. Check how much water and fuel that day requires. Then multiply that complete day to reach your household target.

MORNING

Oats, shelf-stable milk, dried fruit, or another familiar breakfast.

MAIN MEALS

Rice, lentils, pasta, canned foods, or other simple combinations.

NO-COOK BACKUP

Nut butter, crackers, nuts, dried fruit, or ready-to-eat cans.

DO NOT FORGET

Oil, salt, seasonings, safe water, fuel, and special dietary foods.

Easy shopping method

Each time you shop, buy one or two extra shelf-stable foods that your household already uses. Write the date on them, place them behind older supplies, and keep building until every person-day is covered.

PREVENT WASTE

Rotate your food

First in

FIRST OUT

Use the oldest food first, then replace what you use. Emergency food should not sit forgotten for years.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple food kit

☐ Rice

☐ Lentils or beans

☐ Oats or other grains

☐ Canned foods

☐ Nut butter

☐ Nuts and seeds

☐ Dried fruit

☐ Cooking oil

☐ Salt and seasonings

☐ Manual can opener

☐ Cooking pot and utensils

☐ Safe cooking method

☐ Food-storage containers

☐ Labels and marker

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Store foods no one will eat.

✗ Depend only on foods that require long cooking.

✗ Forget the water and fuel cooking requires.

✗ Store large amounts without rotating them.

✗ Open refrigerated food repeatedly during an outage.

✗ Eat questionable food to avoid waste.

✗ Forget special dietary or medical needs.

✗ Assume calories are the only thing that matters.

PLAN FOR REAL NEEDS

Special needs

Some people may need infant formula, soft foods, low-sodium foods, diabetic-friendly foods, allergy-safe foods, or foods that are easy to chew or digest. Pets also need food.

Emergency planning should include the people and animals who actually live with you.

TRY THIS NOW

Food practice

Choose one day. Pretend there is no electricity and you cannot go to the store. Prepare every meal using only food you have, your emergency cooking method, and limited water.

1. Did I have enough food, and was it satisfying?
2. Did it require too much cooking fuel?
3. Did I use too much water?
4. Was anything missing?
5. Could I eat this way for a week?

This is one of the easiest ways to discover weaknesses in your food plan.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have several days of familiar food.

☐ I have no-cook and quick-cooking foods.

☐ I have a safe way to cook without normal utilities.

☐ I have enough cooking fuel and a manual can opener.

☐ I have salt, oil, and simple seasonings.

☐ I rotate my stored food.

☐ I have considered special dietary needs.

☐ I know how much water my stored foods require.

REMEMBER

Emergency food does not need to be fancy.

Simple food that can be stored, cooked, and shared is valuable.

A handful of rice and beans in a real shortage can be worth more than gold.

STORE SIMPLE. COOK SIMPLE. WASTE NOTHING.

Official guidance

Use current food-safety instructions during an outage, flood, or other emergency.

FDA: Food and Water Safety During Power Outages and Floods (<https://www.fda.gov/food/buy-store-serve-safe-food/food-and-water-safety-during-power-outages-and-floods>)

USDA: Food Safety During Temporary Power Outages (<https://www.usda.gov/about-usda/news/blog/avoid-foodborne-illness-during-temporary-power-outages>)

American Red Cross: Survival Kit Supplies(<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/survival-kit-supplies.html>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Sprouting

Turn Stored Seeds Into Fresh Food

Sprouting is one of the simplest ways to produce fresh food without soil, a garden, or electricity. A small amount of dry seed can become a much larger amount of fresh food using water, a container, and a little time.

Seed + Water + Time = Fresh food

COMPACT FOOD POTENTIAL

Why sprouting matters

Dry seeds store well and take up very little space. Once sprouted, they become fresh living food that can add freshness, variety, vitamins and minerals, texture, and additional food volume when vegetables are unavailable.

CHOOSE FOOD-GRADE SEED

What can you sprout?

- Lentils
- Mung beans
- Alfalfa
- Clover
- Radish
- Broccoli
- Peas
- Adzuki beans
- Fenugreek
- Other seeds sold for sprouting

Use seeds intended for human consumption and sprouting. Garden seeds may have been chemically treated and should not automatically be considered food.

The simple jar method

Clean glass jar

Sprouting seeds

Safe drinking water

Mesh lid or clean cloth

STEP 1

Add seeds

Put a small amount into the jar. A tablespoon or two is enough to learn with. Seeds expand considerably.

STEP 2

Soak

Cover generously with clean water. Exact timing varies by seed, but overnight is adequate for many common varieties.

STEP 3

Drain

Pour away the soaking water. Seeds should remain moist but never sit submerged.

STEP 4

Rinse

Rinse with clean drinking water and drain thoroughly, generally two or three times each day.

STEP 5

Let them grow

Keep at normal room temperature with air circulation, protected from dirt and insects, and out of strong direct sunlight.

STEP 6

Use promptly

When ready, rinse and drain thoroughly. Add them to soups, stews, rice, lentils, stir-fries, flatbreads, or cooked vegetable dishes.

Moist, not soaking wet.

FOOD SAFETY COMES FIRST

Cleanliness is essential

The same conditions that help seeds grow can also allow harmful bacteria to multiply.

Warmth + Moisture + Time

☐ Start with clean hands.

☐ Use clean jars and equipment.

☐ Use safe drinking water.

☐ Use seed intended for sprouting.

☐ Drain the sprouts well.

☐ Keep the sprouting area clean.

☐ Discard anything questionable.

Raw sprouts carry risk

Contamination may already be present inside or on the seed. Even sprouts grown carefully at home can occasionally carry harmful bacteria.

HIGHER-RISK GROUPS

- Young children.
- Pregnant people.
- Older adults.
- People with weakened immune systems.

People in higher-risk groups should avoid raw or lightly cooked sprouts. Thorough cooking reduces food-safety risk.

DO NOT SAVE A BAD BATCH

When to throw them away

✗ An unpleasant or rotten smell.

✗ Sliminess.

✗ Obvious mold.

✗ Unusual discoloration.

✗ Any sign of contamination.

A handful of seed is not worth becoming sick over.

DRINKING WATER COMES FIRST

Sprouts and water

Sprouting requires clean water. In a severe shortage, drinking water always comes first.

Sprouting can still be efficient because seed can produce fresh food without irrigating a garden, fertilizer, soil, sunlight, or cooking fuel during growth. Plan around the clean water you actually have.

START SMALL AND LEARN

How much seed should you store?

You do not need enormous quantities to begin. Sprouting seed is compact, lightweight, easy to divide, easy to rotate, and capable of producing food repeatedly.

Start with 2 or 3 varieties

CHOOSE SEEDS YOUR HOUSEHOLD WILL ACTUALLY EAT

Practice first, then learn how much your household uses. Store knowledge along with the seeds. A bucket of seed is much less useful if nobody knows how to sprout it.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple sprouting kit

☐ Sprouting seeds

☐ Glass jars

☐ Mesh lids or screens

☐ Clean cloth as backup

☐ Clean drinking water

☐ Measuring spoon

☐ Drain rack or bowl

☐ Labels and marker

☐ Printed instructions

A commercial sprouting tray can be useful, but it is not necessary.

GOOD FIRST CHOICES

Start with easy sprouts

EASY AND FAMILIAR

Lentils

Inexpensive and simple to learn with.

SUBSTANTIAL GROWTH

Mung beans

Useful in many cooked dishes.

FLAVORFUL GREENS

Radish or broccoli

Small seeds that produce green sprouts.

Learn two or three varieties well before maintaining a large collection.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Use chemically treated garden seed.

✗ Use questionable water.

✗ Put too many seeds into one jar.

✗ Leave sprouts sitting in water.

✗ Forget to rinse and drain them.

✗ Allow dirty hands or utensils into the jar.

✗ Assume homegrown sprouts are automatically free of bacteria.

✗ Eat sprouts that smell bad or appear moldy.

✗ Depend on sprouting for all food.

Sprouting should complement stored staple foods, not replace them.

A POWERFUL COMBINATION

Staples plus sprouts

STORED FOUNDATION

Rice + Beans + Lentils +
Oats

+

FRESH ADDITION

Mung + Lentil + Broccoli +
Radish Sprouts

Together, stored staples and sprouting provide far more flexibility than either one alone.

TRY THIS NOW

Sprouting practice

Start with **one tablespoon of lentils**.

1. Put them in a clean jar and cover with water.
2. Soak overnight, then drain.
3. Rinse and drain morning and evening.
4. Watch what happens over the next few days.
5. Eat them in a thoroughly cooked meal.

Ask how much food the tablespoon produced, how much water it used, how long it took, and whether you could repeat it without instructions.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have seeds suitable for sprouting.

☐ I have actually sprouted them before.

☐ I have clean jars or trays and a way to drain them.

☐ I know which varieties my household will eat.

☐ I understand that cleanliness is essential.

☐ I know that raw sprouts carry food-safety risk.

☐ I can recognize and discard a bad batch.

☐ I have written instructions if the internet is down.

REMEMBER

Seeds are food in storage and fresh food waiting to happen.

You do not need soil, a garden, or electricity to sprout them.

Clean seed, clean water, clean equipment, and good drainage matter.

STORE THE SEED. ADD WATER. GROW FOOD.

Official guidance

Food-safety authorities advise higher-risk people to avoid raw or lightly cooked sprouts and recommend thorough cooking to reduce risk.

CDC Archive: Sprout Safety Advice(https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/salmonella/montevideo-01-18/advice.html)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Food From the Land

Learn What Already Grows Around You

Useful food may already be growing nearby: berries, nuts, edible greens, seeds, roots, fruits, and mushrooms. But wild food is only useful when you know exactly what it is.

LEARN A FEW THINGS WELL.

START BEFORE THE EMERGENCY

Build local knowledge now

1

Walk the land in spring, summer, and fall. Notice what changes.

2

Choose one common, distinctive local plant to study.

3

Learn its features, look-alikes, edible part, season, and preparation.

4

Confirm it with an experienced local person or trusted regional authority.

THE USEFUL RULE

Five plants you know with certainty are more valuable than fifty plants you vaguely remember.

CERTAINTY BEFORE EATING

Positive identification

Never eat a plant because it resembles one picture, an app calls it “probably edible,” an animal ate it, or you remember something similar. Confirm several characteristics together.

STRUCTURE

Leaves, stem, bark, branching, thorns, and growth pattern.

REPRODUCTION

Flowers, fruit, seed heads, spores, and their arrangement.

PLACE

Habitat, soil, moisture, elevation, and nearby species.

TIME

Season and the plant’s appearance at several growth stages.

If you cannot positively identify it and rule out dangerous look-alikes, do not eat it.

LOCAL KNOWLEDGE MATTERS

Learn from someone who knows

Walk with an experienced local naturalist, extension educator, forager, or botanical group. Use a reliable regional field guide, take photographs and notes, and return through the seasons.

Start with foods that are common, distinctive, and difficult to confuse. The correct list is local: New York, Florida, and Arizona should not share the same beginner list.

Know one plant completely before adding another.

EXTRA CAUTION REQUIRED

Mushrooms require special care

Some edible and poisonous mushrooms look very similar. Color, smell, insect damage, silver darkening, and easy peeling are not reliable shortcuts. You need the exact species.

✗ Depend on a phone app for a final identification.

✗ Assume cooking or drying destroys mushroom toxins.

✗ Make wild mushrooms a beginner emergency-food strategy.

✗ Eat a mushroom unless an expert-level identification is certain.

For beginners: do not depend on wild mushrooms for emergency food. Learn with expert guidance.

Where you harvest matters

Avoid plants growing beside busy roads, industrial sites, dumps, chemically treated lawns, sprayed fields, contaminated water, or other visibly polluted areas.

STOP

Unknown contamination

If you cannot determine the land's treatment or pollution history, choose another site.

CHECK

Permission and rules

Ask the landowner and check current rules or permit requirements on public land.

RECORD

Site conditions

Note nearby roads, water, spraying, waste, livestock, and runoff on your field map.

IDENTIFICATION IS ONLY THE BEGINNING

Know the part, season, and preparation

An edible plant does not necessarily have all edible parts. The useful portion may be only the fruit, leaf, root, seed, flower, or young shoot.

What part? + What season? +
How prepared?

Some wild foods are eaten raw; others require cooking, boiling, soaking, drying, shelling, or removal of specific parts. Learn the traditional safe preparation for the exact species.

Do not nibble an unknown plant to test it. Taste cannot prove safety.

A SUPPLEMENT, NOT A FOUNDATION

Use wild food realistically

Wild food changes with season, weather, drought, wildlife, location, and competition. Stored staples provide reliability; local foods can add freshness, variety, nutrients, and calories.

RELIABLE FOUNDATION

Rice + Beans + Lentils +
Oats

+

LOCAL SUPPLEMENT

Known Greens + Berries +
Nuts + Seeds

Think of the land as an additional resource, not an unlimited supermarket.

PROTECT THE RESOURCE

Harvest responsibly

☐ Take only what you need.

☐ Leave enough for the plant to reproduce.

☐ Leave food and habitat for wildlife.

☐ Avoid damaging roots unless the root itself is the food.

☐ Do not collect rare or protected plants.

☐ Follow landowner rules, permits, and local laws.

Keep a local food map

Create a paper map or notebook. Record every candidate with four practical fields, but do not mark it “confirmed” until identification and safe preparation have been verified.

What

Common and scientific name; identifying features and look-alikes.

Where

Exact location, access permission, and contamination check.

When

Month, growth stage, and usable harvest window.

How

Edible part, preparation, storage, and safety notes.

Blank field record

PLANT _____

LOCATION _____

SEASON _____

FEATURES _____

LOOK-
ALIKES _____

EDIBLE
PART _____

PREPARAT
ION _____

CONFIRM
ED BY _____

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple foraging kit

☐ Local field guide

☐ Notebook and pencil

☐ Paper map

☐ Basket or cloth bags

☐ Gloves

☐ Small knife or scissors

☐ Drinking water

☐ Appropriate clothing

☐ Whistle

☐ Basic first-aid supplies

☐ Property boundaries

☐ Current local rules

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Eat something you cannot positively identify.

✗ Depend entirely on a phone identification app.

✗ Assume a plant is safe because animals eat it.

✗ Use taste as an identification method.

✗ Assume every part of an edible plant is edible.

✗ Gather beside polluted roads or contaminated areas.

✗ Depend on wild mushrooms without expertise.

✗ Harvest everything you find.

✗ Wait until an emergency to begin learning.

TRY THIS NOW

Local food practice

Choose one edible wild plant that grows commonly near you. **Do not eat it yet.**

1. Record its common and scientific names.
2. Describe its leaves, stem, flower, fruit, habitat, and season.
3. List dangerous look-alikes and their differences.
4. Identify the edible part and required preparation.
5. Check harvesting permission and local rules.
6. Find it in the real world with someone knowledgeable, if possible.

Once you can identify that one plant confidently, learn another.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I know several edible plants that actually grow near me.

☐ I can identify them without depending on the internet.

☐ I know their dangerous look-alikes.

☐ I know which parts are edible and when they are available.

☐ I know how they must be prepared.

☐ I avoid contaminated harvesting areas.

☐ I understand that mushrooms require greater expertise.

☐ I have a printed local field guide and food map.

REMEMBER

The land can provide food, but only knowledge makes that food useful.

Do not try to know everything. Know a few things with certainty.

If you are not sure, leave it alone.

KNOW IT. FIND IT. USE IT WISELY.

Official guidance

Use these references to reinforce local instruction, not to identify a meal from a webpage alone.

Penn State Extension: Preparing and Preserving Mushrooms(<https://extension.psu.edu/preparing-and-preserving-mushrooms>)

USDA Forest Service: Positive Identification and Roadside Safety (<https://www.fs.usda.gov/r01/idaho/pamphlets/animals-plants/edible-and-medicinal-plants-north-idaho>)

USDA: Foraging and Harvesting Best Practices (<https://www.usda.gov/sites/default/files/documents/foraging-harvesting-indigenous-wild-plants-best-practices.pdf>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Sanitation

Keep Waste Away From People, Food, and Water

When toilets and running water stop working, sanitation can become a serious problem quickly. Food and shelter are not enough if human waste and dirty hands begin spreading disease.

CONTAIN IT. SEPARATE IT. KEEP CLEAN.

IF THE TOILETS STOP WORKING

First determine what failed

WATER SUPPLY OFF, SEWER WORKING**Manual flushing may be possible**

Use non-drinking water only after confirming the sewer or septic system is functioning and local officials have not told you to stop flushing.

SEWER, SEPTIC, OR DRAIN SYSTEM FAILED**Stop flushing**

Do not add more wastewater to a failed system. Set up an emergency toilet and follow local disposal instructions.

BACKFLOW WARNING

If sewage is backing up, keep people away from it and contact the utility, property manager, or septic professional.

Simple emergency toilet

Use a purpose-made emergency toilet system when available. For a short-term household backup, a sturdy lined toilet bowl or stable bucket can contain waste until authorities provide disposal instructions.

STEP 1

Line it

Place a strong plastic bag securely inside the empty toilet bowl or a stable bucket fitted with a toilet seat.

STEP 2

Absorb

After each use, cover waste with cat litter, sawdust, or wood shavings to absorb moisture and reduce odor.

STEP 3

Remove early

Do not let the bag become heavy or overfilled. Wear gloves and remove it carefully while it is still manageable.

STEP 4

Seal and label

Close the bag tightly, place it in a second bag if needed, and label it as human waste.

STEP 5

Separate

Keep sealed waste away from people, animals, food, and all water sources. Follow local public-health or waste-authority disposal directions.

Bag → Absorbent material → Seal → Separate

THE STRONGEST DAILY DEFENSE

Handwashing

Wash after using the toilet, handling waste, changing diapers, and before preparing food, eating, or caring for wounds.

Scrub for at least 20 seconds

USE SOAP AND SAFE WATER WHENEVER POSSIBLE

1

Wet

Wet hands with clean running or poured water.

2

Lather

Apply soap and rub palms, backs of hands, between fingers, and beneath nails.

3

Rinse and dry

Rinse with clean water and use a clean towel, paper towel, or air dry.

If soap and water are unavailable, use alcohol-based hand sanitizer containing at least 60% alcohol. Sanitizer is a fallback, not a replacement when hands are visibly dirty.

NO RUNNING PLUMBING REQUIRED

Simple handwashing station

SUPPLY

Water jug with spigot

Raise it above hand level so water can flow without touching the outlet.

WASH

Soap and drying method

Keep pump soap and clean paper towels or another clean drying method beside it.

CATCH

Basin or bucket

Collect wastewater so it does not create mud, slipping, or contamination.

Place one station near the emergency toilet and another near food preparation. Refill them with safe water and keep the spigot clean.

CREATE A HARD BOUNDARY

Protect the drinking water

✗ Empty waste near a well, spring, stream, pond, or stored water.

✗ Wash toilet equipment near drinking-water storage.

✗ Put dirty hands, cups, or utensils into clean-water containers.

✗ Use the same containers for waste and drinking water.

**Keep the toilet area downhill and away from any water source whenever site conditions allow.
Follow local rules for waste storage and disposal.**

CREATE TWO CLEARLY SEPARATED ZONES

Clean zone

Drinking water, clean containers, cooking utensils, food preparation, wound care

Waste zone

Emergency toilet, sealed human waste, garbage, wastewater, contaminated equipment

CONTROL WASTE IN ONE PLACE

Garbage and food preparation

Keep garbage bagged, covered, protected from animals and insects, and away from living areas, food, and drinking water. Establish one controlled garbage area instead of allowing trash to accumulate throughout the shelter.

A dirty kitchen can spread illness as easily as a dirty toilet. Keep hands, utensils, work surfaces, and food coverings clean. Anyone who handles human waste must wash thoroughly before touching food.

USE LIMITED WATER WHERE IT MATTERS

Personal cleanliness and special needs

When normal showers are unavailable, concentrate on hands, face, feet, underarms, groin, and wounds. Never bathe in water contaminated by sewage, floodwater, or toxic chemicals.

Plan for infants, older adults, and anyone with individual sanitation needs. Store diapers, protective underwear, wipes, gloves, skin-protection products, menstrual supplies, and needed disposal bags.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple sanitation kit

☐ Strong plastic bags

☐ Absorbent material

☐ Toilet paper

☐ Soap

☐ 60%+ alcohol hand sanitizer

☐ Disposable gloves

☐ Water jug with spigot

☐ Paper towels

☐ Garbage bags and ties

☐ Cleaning supplies

☐ Stable bucket or commode

☐ Personal sanitation supplies

☐ Labels and marker

☐ Printed local instructions

PREVENT DANGEROUS MIX-UPS

Keep everything labeled

Use large permanent lettering on the container and lid. Color alone is not enough, and no one should have to remember which bucket is which.

DRINKING WATER

WASHING WATER

HUMAN WASTE

GARBAGE

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Keep flushing when the sewer or septic system is not working.

✗ Allow human waste to remain uncovered.

✗ Put waste near food or drinking water.

✗ Forget to wash after handling waste or removing gloves.

✗ Use drinking-water containers for waste.

✗ Allow garbage to build up in living areas.

✗ Handle waste and then prepare food without washing.

✗ Guess how bagged waste should be disposed of instead of checking local instructions.

✗ Wait until toilets fail to assemble supplies.

TRY THIS NOW

Three-day sanitation practice

Imagine the toilets and running water will not work for three days. Without using the emergency toilet, set up the complete system and answer:

1. Which bag and absorbent material will we use?
2. Where will the stable emergency toilet stand?
3. Where will sealed waste be isolated?
4. How will everyone wash and dry their hands?
5. Where will garbage and collected wastewater go?
6. How will drinking water remain protected?
7. Whom will we contact for disposal instructions?

Place the supplies together and make sure everyone can find them in the dark.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have strong bags, absorbent material, and toilet paper.

☐ I have soap, gloves, and effective hand sanitizer.

☐ I can set up a stable emergency toilet.

☐ I can create a handwashing station without plumbing.

☐ I know where sealed waste would be isolated.

☐ I can keep waste away from food and water.

☐ I have a controlled garbage plan.

☐ I have considered diapers and individual hygiene needs.

☐ I know where to get current local disposal instructions.

REMEMBER

A shelter without sanitation will not remain safe for long.

Human waste must be contained. Clean hands protect food and water.

BAG IT. ABSORB IT. SEAL IT. KEEP IT SEPARATE.

Official guidance

Check current local instructions during an emergency, especially for sewer use and human-waste disposal.

CDC: Personal Hygiene During an
Emergency

(<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/safety/guidelines-for-personal-hygiene-during-an-emergency.html>)

CDC Archive: Sanitation Solutions During an
Emergency

(https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/global/sanitation/sanitation-emergency-response.html)

FEMA: Basic Emergency Supply Kit

(<https://www.fema.gov/print/pdf/node/503732>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

First Aid & Medicine

Stop the Immediate Problem. Get Help
When Needed.

Small injuries can become serious when ignored. Basic first aid helps control bleeding, protect wounds, cool burns, recognize danger, and keep a problem from becoming worse until proper care is available.

PROTECT LIFE. CONTROL THE PROBLEM. GET HELP.

FIRST: IS IT AN EMERGENCY?

Call 911 or local emergency services when available

Not breathing normally

Unresponsive

Severe bleeding

Serious chest pain

Signs of stroke

Severe breathing difficulty

Major, chemical, or electrical burns

Serious head or spinal injury

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, call for help, begin CPR, and use an AED according to your training and the device prompts. Do not delay emergency care to keep reading.

Severe bleeding

1

Make it safe

Check the scene, call emergency services, and put on disposable gloves if available.

2

Find the source

Expose the wound enough to see where the blood is coming from. Do not remove an embedded object.

3

Apply pressure

Put clean gauze or cloth directly over the wound and press firmly and steadily.

4

Keep pressure

Do not repeatedly lift the original dressing to check. Maintain direct pressure until bleeding stops, trained help takes over, or the scene becomes unsafe.

5

Use trained skills

For life-threatening bleeding from an arm or leg, use a manufactured tourniquet if trained. Note the application time and do not loosen it.

Call

Activate
emergency
help

**Locate**

Expose the
bleeding
source

**Press**

Firm pressure
with gauze or
cloth

**Hold**

Do not keep
lifting to check

Severe continuous or spurting bleeding requires immediate emergency medical treatment.

Small cuts and wounds

1

Clean hands

Wash your hands and use gloves when available.

2

Control bleeding

Use gentle direct pressure with clean gauze.

3

Rinse and cover

Rinse with clean water, remove only obvious surface dirt that comes away safely, and apply a clean dressing.

4

Monitor

Keep the wound clean and watch it over the following days.

Increasing redness

Swelling

Warmth

Pus

Increasing pain

Fever

Seek medical care for deep or badly contaminated wounds, animal bites, uncontrolled bleeding, loss of function, or signs of infection. Ask a clinician about tetanus protection when appropriate.

COOL IT, DO NOT CONTAMINATE IT

Minor thermal burns

1

Stop the burning

Move away from the heat source and make the scene safe.

2

Cool with water

Place the burn under clean, cool running water for 5 to 20 minutes. Do not use ice.

3

Remove loose items

Remove jewelry or loose clothing near the burn unless it is stuck to the skin.

4

Protect loosely

Use a clean, dry, non-adhesive dressing if needed.

Call emergency services for major burns. Seek urgent evaluation for chemical or electrical burns, deep burns, large areas, or burns of the face, mouth, neck, hands, feet, joints, or groin.

✗ Apply ice directly.

✗ Apply butter, grease, toothpaste, petroleum jelly, or other home remedies.

✗ Pull away clothing stuck to burned skin.

✗ Break blisters.

PROTECT THE INJURED AREA

Sprains and strains

Stop the activity, protect the injury, use a wrapped cold pack for short periods, elevate it if comfortable, and avoid unnecessary weight on a badly injured joint.

Seek medical care for severe pain, deformity, inability to use the limb, numbness, loss of circulation, or concern for a fracture.

RECOGNIZE THE WARNING SIGNS

Dehydration

Thirst

Dry mouth

Weakness

Dizziness

Dark urine

Reduced urination

Confusion

Fainting

Give safe fluids only when the person is awake, able to swallow, and not vomiting repeatedly. Severe dehydration, confusion, fainting, or inability to keep fluids down requires medical attention.

DAILY MEDICINE MAY BE LIFESAVING

Personal medications

Talk with a doctor or pharmacist about an appropriate emergency supply. Keep an up-to-date medication list with the drug name, purpose, dose, timing, allergies, medical conditions, pharmacy, and prescriber.

Protect the supply

Keep medicines in original labeled containers, stored dry and within the temperature limits on the label. Use a waterproof container if flooding or water damage is possible.

Medicines that need refrigeration

Some medicines, including certain insulin and liquid medicines, lose strength outside their required temperature range. Ask the pharmacist or manufacturer exactly how long each product can remain unrefrigerated.

☐ I know the labeled storage temperature and allowable time outside it.

☐ I have a cooler and cold packs suitable for the medicine.

☐ I can prevent the medicine from freezing or touching loose ice.

☐ I know where and how to obtain a replacement.

Do not guess whether a temperature-sensitive medicine is safe. Contact a pharmacist, healthcare professional, or manufacturer for product-specific instructions.

ONLY FAMILIAR AND APPROPRIATE PRODUCTS

Basic over-the-counter medicines

☐ Pain and fever medicine

☐ Antihistamine

☐ Antacid

☐ Antidiarrheal medicine

☐ Oral rehydration packets

☐ Other familiar household medicines

Read and follow labels. Check active ingredients to avoid accidental double dosing, and consider age, allergies, pregnancy, medical conditions, and drug interactions. Keep all medicine away from children.

DO NOT GUESS

What about antibiotics?

Antibiotics treat certain bacterial infections, not every illness. Do not use leftovers casually, share prescriptions, guess the drug or dose, or use antibiotics for viral illnesses.

Any antibiotic in an emergency plan should be selected and used under appropriate medical guidance.

KNOW YOUR PEOPLE

Identify essential medical needs

- Insulin
- Heart medicine
- Seizure medicine
- Blood thinners
- Asthma inhalers
- Epinephrine auto-injectors
- Oxygen
- Mobility equipment
- Hearing aids and batteries
- Other essential equipment

A community first-aid kit cannot replace someone's essential daily medicine.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple first-aid kit

☐ Disposable nonlatex gloves

☐ Sterile gauze and bandages

☐ Medical tape

☐ Antiseptic supplies

☐ Clean wound-rinsing water

☐ Elastic bandage

☐ Scissors and tweezers

☐ Cold packs

☐ Thermometer

☐ Basic pain and fever medicine

☐ Personal prescriptions

☐ Medication list

☐ Emergency contacts

☐ Printed first-aid instructions

☐ CPR face shield if trained

☐ Tourniquet with training

KEEP A PAPER COPY WITH THE KIT

Emergency medical information

One sheet per person

NAME	
BIRTH DATE	
CONDITIONS	
MEDICINES	
DOSAGES	
ALLERGIES	
EQUIPMENT	
DOCTOR	
PHARMACY	
CONTACT	

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Delay calling during a life-threatening emergency.

✗ Repeatedly remove pressure from a severely bleeding wound.

✗ Put ice, butter, or grease on burns.

✗ Move someone unnecessarily when spinal injury is suspected.

✗ Give medicine without knowing what it is or checking the label.

✗ Share prescription medicine.

✗ Forget daily medications and medical equipment.

✗ Wait until medicine runs out to seek a replacement.

TRY THIS NOW

First-aid practice

Open the kit rather than simply looking at the box.

1. Find the gloves, gauze, and wound dressings.
2. Explain how you would call for help and control bleeding.
3. Check every medicine and sterile item for damage or expiration.
4. Find the paper medication and allergy lists.
5. Identify the nearest AED and who knows CPR.
6. List each household member's essential medical needs.

Replace missing or expired supplies, then schedule hands-on first-aid, CPR, AED, and bleeding-control training.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have a usable, regularly checked first-aid kit.

☐ I know how to call for help and control serious bleeding.

☐ I know basic wound and burn care.

☐ I have medication, allergy, condition, and contact lists.

☐ Essential prescriptions and equipment are in the plan.

☐ I know the exact requirements for refrigerated medicines.

☐ I know where the nearest AED is.

☐ At least one person has current first-aid and CPR training.

REMEMBER

The first job of first aid is not to become a doctor.

Keep a problem from becoming worse until proper help is available.

**PROTECT LIFE. CONTROL THE PROBLEM.
GET HELP.**

Official guidance and training

Written instructions support preparedness but do not replace hands-on training or professional medical care.

American Red Cross: Life-Threatening External Bleeding (<https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/resources/learn-first-aid/bleeding-life-threatening-external>)

American Red Cross: Burns(<https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/resources/learn-first-aid/burns>)

American Red Cross: First-Aid Kit(<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/anatomy-of-a-first-aid-kit.html>)

CDC: Emergency Prescription Planning(<https://www.cdc.gov/prepare-your-health/take-action/prescriptions.html>)

FDA: Safe Drug Use After a Natural Disaster (<https://www.fda.gov/drugs/emergency-preparedness-drugs/safe-drug-use-after-natural-disaster>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Tools

The Right Tool Makes Resources Useful

Food, water, wood, shelter materials, and repair supplies are useful only when you can work with them. A few dependable hand tools can do an enormous amount when electricity, fuel, or outside help is unavailable.

KEEP SIMPLE TOOLS. KNOW HOW TO USE THEM.

START WITH HAND TOOLS

Choose tools that still work without the grid

No electricity required

No charged battery required

No fuel required

Repairable and maintainable

BEFORE EVERY USE

Inspect the tool, choose the right tool for the job, wear suitable protection, clear the work area, and stop if the task exceeds your skill.

Basic emergency tool kit

CUTTING AND WOOD

Shape and prepare

- Hand saw
- Bow saw
- Axe
- Splitting maul
- Hatchet
- Utility knife

DIGGING AND MOVING

Lift and clear

- Shovel
- Spade
- Rake
- Pry bar
- Buckets

REPAIR

Adjust and restore

- Hammer
- Screwdrivers
- Pliers
- Adjustable wrench
- Socket or wrench set
- Pipe wrench
- Tape measure

FASTENING

Hold and cover

- Nails and screws
- Wire
- Rope and cord
- Duct tape
- Zip ties
- Tarps

Wood tools

If you depend on wood for heat or cooking, you need a way to cut, split, move, and keep it dry.

Bow saw + Axe + Splitting maul + Gloves

These four items can accomplish a great deal without fuel or electricity, but cutting and splitting require instruction, a clear work zone, secure footing, and eye protection.

INSPECT BEFORE THE EMERGENCY

Keep tools usable

Edges	Sharp, clean, and protected from damage.	Handles	Tight, dry, and free of cracks or splinters.
Metal	Free of serious rust, bends, or loose heads.	Moving parts	Clean, correctly adjusted, and lightly lubricated when appropriate.
Blades	Saw teeth straight and suitable for the material.	Supplies	Files, sharpening stones, spare blades, oil, and replacement handles available.

A dull or damaged cutting tool may require more force and can be harder to control. Learn the correct maintenance method for each tool.

SIMPLE ITEMS, MANY USES

Rope, tarps, and buckets

SECURE

Rope or cord

Tie down loads, hang tarps, organize equipment, and support temporary repairs. Never trust unknown cordage for climbing or life safety.

COVER

Tarps

Protect roof damage, firewood, equipment, windows, and temporary shelter from weather.

CARRY

Buckets

Move water, food, soil, ashes, cleaning water, and supplies. Label buckets by use.

PREVENT THE NEXT PROBLEM

Temporary repairs

A permanent repair may be impossible during an emergency. The immediate goal may be to stop water entry, cover a broken window, hold a door shut, slow a pipe leak, or protect supplies from rain.

Do not climb onto an unstable roof, enter a damaged structure, or improvise near live utilities. A repair is not worth another injury.

KNOW THE VALVE, NOT JUST THE WRENCH

Water and plumbing tools

☐ Adjustable wrench

☐ Pipe wrench

☐ Pliers

☐ Screwdrivers

☐ Plumbing tape

☐ Hose clamps

☐ Spare washers

☐ Buckets

Find the main water shutoff now

Tag it clearly, verify that it is operable without forcing it, keep the correct tool nearby, and show responsible household members where it is.

WATER AND ELECTRICITY ARE A DANGEROUS COMBINATION

Electrical safety

Locate and label the main electrical panel and important circuits before an emergency. Teach responsible household members the approved shutoff procedure for the building.

Do not touch exposed wiring, enter standing water near electrical equipment, or work on a live system. Repairs belong to a qualified electrician.

LEARN THE EXACT PROCEDURE FROM THE SUPPLIER

Gas and fuel shutoffs

Natural gas, propane, oil, and other fuel systems differ. Ask the supplier or a qualified professional which valve applies, which tool is required, and when it should be operated.

✗ Actually shut off gas merely to practice.

✗ Operate an unfamiliar valve by guessing.

✗ Turn gas service back on yourself after it has been shut off.

✗ Remain in a building if you smell gas or hear blowing or hissing.

If gas is suspected, avoid flames and electrical switches, get everyone out, and call the gas company or emergency services from a safe location.

MAKE TOOLS EASY TO FIND

Keep tools together

Create a clearly labeled emergency-tool area. Keep priority tools and utility shutoff tools accessible, not buried behind stored supplies. Use a return system if several people share them.

Emergency Tools

ONE KNOWN LOCATION, CLEARLY LABELED

SAFETY EQUIPMENT IS PART OF THE KIT

Protect the person using the tool

☐ Work gloves suited to the task

☐ Safety glasses

☐ Hearing protection when needed

☐ Task-appropriate respiratory protection

☐ Sturdy shoes or boots

☐ First-aid kit

☐ Headlamp or flashlight

☐ Clear, well-lit work area

Do not use a tool you do not understand

Chainsaws, axes, generators, power saws, ladders, and electrical equipment can create another emergency when used without training. Read the manual, learn from a competent person, and practice under normal conditions.

A tool you know how to use is worth more than ten tools you do not understand.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Depend entirely on power tools.

✗ Keep tools where nobody can find them.

✗ Use dull cutting tools or damaged handles.

✗ Use an axe or saw without a clear work zone.

✗ Work alone on a hazardous task when help is available.

✗ Use electrical tools around standing water.

✗ Attempt repairs beyond your knowledge or training.

✗ Forget protective equipment.

✗ Own critical tools you have never used.

TRY THIS NOW

Five-tool practice

Choose the five tools you expect to matter most, such as a hand saw, axe, hammer, adjustable wrench, and shovel.

1. Find each tool without searching.
2. Inspect its edge, handle, moving parts, and overall condition.
3. Identify its protective equipment and safe work zone.
4. Explain how it is maintained or sharpened.
5. Use it for one small, low-risk task under normal conditions.
6. Ask another person to locate it without your help.

For utility shutoffs, practice locating and explaining them without actually shutting off gas.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have basic hand tools and know where they are.

☐ Cutting tools are maintained and handles are secure.

☐ I have rope, tarps, buckets, and repair supplies.

☐ I know and have labeled the main water shutoff.

☐ I know where the electrical panel is.

☐ I obtained correct gas or fuel instructions from the supplier.

☐ Shutoff tools are accessible.

☐ I have gloves, eye protection, and sturdy footwear.

☐ I have practiced with the tools I expect to depend on.

REMEMBER

Natural resources become useful when you can work with them.

Simple hand tools do not need electricity.

KEEP IT SIMPLE. KEEP IT SHARP. KNOW HOW TO USE IT.

Official guidance

Always follow manufacturer instructions, local utility directions, and task-specific training.

Ready.gov: Utility Safety Skills(<https://www.ready.gov/safety-skills>)

Ready.gov: Build an Emergency Kit(<https://www.ready.gov/kit>)

OSHA: Hand and Power Tools(<https://www.osha.gov/hand-power-tools>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Light, Power & Communication

See. Charge. Listen. Stay Connected.

When electricity goes out, lights, phones, internet, refrigeration, heating controls, medical devices, and communication systems can fail together. A layered backup plan can make a major difference.

HAVE MORE THAN ONE WAY TO SEE, POWER, AND COMMUNICATE.

WHEN THE POWER FAILS

Stabilize the first ten minutes

1

Turn on a flashlight or headlamp before moving through dark rooms.

2

Check for immediate hazards, medical-device needs, official alerts, and extreme indoor temperatures.

3

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed.

4

Disconnect sensitive electronics if surges are possible, and begin conserving phone power.

5

Tell household members what happened, where supplies are, and when the next update will be.

LIGHT COMES FIRST

Make safe movement possible

Keep flashlights, headlamps, lanterns, and matching spare batteries easy to reach. Headlamps leave both hands free for stairs, repairs, first aid, and carrying supplies.

LOCATION ONE

Beside each bed

Reach it before standing in the dark.

LOCATION TWO

Near main exits

Find shoes, keys, and a safe way out.

Battery-powered lights are generally safer than candles. Never leave any open flame unattended or burning while people sleep.

A DISCHARGED BACKUP IS NOT A BACKUP

Keep phones and batteries ready

☐ Correct charging cables

☐ Charged power banks

☐ Vehicle charger

☐ Rechargeable batteries

☐ Battery charger

☐ Solar charger where practical

Set a recharge routine

Check power banks and rechargeable batteries on a repeating calendar date. Label each with its cable, capacity, and last-check date.

SAVE POWER BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Conserve limited battery power

Reserve the phone for emergency calls, important texts, weather, official alerts, maps, and essential coordination.

- Lower screen brightness.
- Use low-power mode.
- Stop video streaming.
- Close unnecessary apps.
- Disable unneeded background activity.
- Use airplane mode when no connection is needed.

Generator safety

At least 20 feet outdoors

Keep generators away from windows, doors, attached garages, and other building openings. Point exhaust away from occupied buildings.

GENERATOR PLACEMENT

Occupied building
Keep openings closed
nearby

At least 20 feet
Exhaust points away →

Generator
Outdoors and dry

- ✗ Run a generator inside a house, garage, basement, shed, or carport.
- ✗ Connect it directly to household wiring without approved transfer equipment installed by a qualified electrician.
- ✗ Operate it in rain, flooding, or other wet conditions.
- ✗ Refuel a hot or running generator.

✗ Use it without working carbon-monoxide alarms.

Read the manual, calculate loads, store fuel safely, and practice operation before an emergency.

RUN WHAT MATTERS MOST

Decide what truly needs power

1 Essential medical equipment

2 Communication and official information

3 Critical medicine or food refrigeration

4 Safe lighting

5 Small necessary devices

Record each device's wattage, plug type, battery runtime, and backup method. A generator or battery station must never be overloaded.

Have a battery or hand-crank radio

A radio can carry weather warnings, evacuation instructions, and local emergency information. Keep compatible spare batteries beside it.

Write down local stations now

WEATHER RADIO

LOCAL AM

LOCAL FM

COUNTY ALERTS

DO NOT STORE EVERYTHING IN ONE PHONE

Keep important information offline

☐ Family phone numbers

☐ Emergency contacts

☐ Doctors and pharmacy

☐ Important addresses

☐ Local map

☐ Evacuation routes

☐ Medical information

☐ Emergency procedures

☐ Water-treatment instructions

☐ Shelter locations

A printed page still works when the internet does not.

Meeting and contact plan

Choose one familiar meeting place near home and a second place outside the immediate area. Select a trusted out-of-area contact who can receive each person’s location and status.

Household communication card

NEARBY
MEETING

AREA MEETING

OUT-OF-AREA
CONTACT

CONTACT
NUMBER

BACKUP NUMBER

LOCAL
EMERGENCY

Print a copy for each person’s wallet, bag, or coat and post one at home. Review it whenever information changes.

KEEP MESSAGES SHORT AND USEFUL

Texting may work when calls do not

During network congestion, texts may go through when voice calls do not, although delivery can be delayed. Limit non-emergency calls and do not repeatedly redial.

SAFE. AT HOME. EVERYONE OK.

LEAVING NOW. GOING TO MEETING PLACE 2.

NEED HELP. AT [LOCATION]. [SHORT PROBLEM].

Call 911 only for emergencies. Do not text or operate a phone while driving.

SIMPLE AND VERIFIED INFORMATION

Community communication

Establish one known information point: a bulletin board, central room, designated radio operator, or scheduled briefing location.

☐ Everyone knows where verified updates are posted.

☐ One person or small team confirms information before sharing it.

☐ The next update time is clearly posted.

☐ People know how to report injuries, hazards, shortages, and missing persons.

☐ Old notices are dated and removed to prevent confusion.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple light and communication kit

☐ Flashlights

☐ Headlamps

☐ Lanterns

☐ Spare batteries

☐ Rechargeable batteries

☐ Battery chargers

☐ Charged power banks

☐ Correct charging cables

☐ Vehicle charger

☐ Solar charger if appropriate

☐ Battery or hand-crank radio

☐ Printed contact plan

☐ Printed local map

☐ Emergency instructions

☐ Permanent marker

☐ Notebook and pencils

Label chargers, battery banks, radios, and cables. Store matched equipment together rather than keeping a box of unidentified cords.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Depend on one flashlight or one charging method.

✗ Leave spare batteries untested and power banks discharged.

✗ Depend entirely on cell phones or the internet.

✗ Run a generator indoors or near building openings.

✗ Waste limited power on nonessential entertainment.

✗ Keep important contacts only in a phone.

✗ Assume family members know where to meet.

✗ Spread information that has not been verified.

TRY THIS NOW

One-hour power-outage practice

One evening, turn off normal lights for one hour without disabling safety systems or essential equipment.

1. Have everyone find a working light.
2. Check batteries and charge a phone from backup power.
3. Tune the radio to a known local station.
4. Use the printed contact and meeting plan.
5. Identify which equipment truly requires electricity.
6. Test one short status message to the out-of-area contact.

Correct anything that was difficult to find, discharged, unlabeled, or unknown.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have working lights beside beds and near exits.

☐ I have tested spare batteries and charged power banks.

☐ I have more than one phone-charging method.

☐ I have a working radio and know local stations.

☐ Important contacts and instructions exist on paper.

☐ Everyone knows both meeting locations.

☐ We have an out-of-area contact.

☐ I have listed equipment that needs priority power.

☐ I know how to operate any generator safely.

REMEMBER

Light helps people move safely. Power should be saved for what matters most.

Communication should never depend on only one system.

SEE. CHARGE. LISTEN. STAY CONNECTED.

Official guidance and planning tools

Follow local emergency alerts, equipment manuals, and utility instructions during an actual outage.

Ready.gov: Power Outages(<https://www.ready.gov/power-outages>)

Ready.gov: Family Emergency Communication Plan	(https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2020-03/family-emergency-communication-planning-document.pdf)
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FCC and FEMA: Emergency Communication Tips(<https://www.fcc.gov/emergency>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

People & Community

Share Skills. Share Work. Help One Another.

In a serious emergency, people may be the most valuable resource of all. A group becomes stronger when people share knowledge, divide responsibilities, check on one another, use resources fairly, and stay organized.

KNOW WHO CAN DO WHAT.

IF PEOPLE ARE GATHERING NOW

Hold a five-minute organizing meeting

1

Account for people and identify anyone injured, missing, isolated, or needing immediate help.

2

Name the most urgent threat: life safety, shelter, water, sanitation, heat, or medical care.

3

Ask who has relevant training and who is physically able to help.

4

Assign one lead and one backup for each active task.

5

Set the time and location for the next short update.

STAY WITHIN TRAINING

Community helpers support safety and professional responders; they do not replace qualified medical, fire, utility, rescue, or law-enforcement personnel.

START WITH PEOPLE, NOT ONLY SUPPLIES

Make a simple skills roster

List what each person can actually do, their level of training, and a backup. Ask permission before sharing personal contact, disability, or medical information.

NAME	SKILL	TRAINING OR LIMITS	BACKUP
Maria	First aid	Current certification	Sam
John	Plumbing	Home repairs	Ann

Include first aid, water treatment, cooking, wood handling, plumbing, electrical work, equipment repair, gardening, supply organization, communication, transportation, languages, and caregiving.

Have backups for essential work

Primary person + Backup person +

Written instructions

Prioritize backups for water, first aid, food, heat, sanitation, and communication. Let the backup observe and practice before an emergency.

Divide the work

WATER

Collect and protect

Treat, store, label, and distribute safe water.

FOOD

Inventory and prepare

Plan simple meals and track use.

SANITATION

Contain and clean

Manage toilets, handwashing, garbage, and hygiene.

FIRST AID

Assess and support

Give trained care and identify when professional help is needed.

HEAT AND FIRE

Control fuel and flame

Operate approved equipment and monitor fire and carbon-monoxide safety.

TOOLS AND REPAIRS

Stabilize problems

Handle tasks within demonstrated skill and training.

COMMUNICATION

Verify and update

Gather official information and post short, dated updates.

PEOPLE

Account and assist

Check children, older adults, visitors, and anyone needing extra support.

ASSIGN, DO NOT ASSUME

Check on people needing extra assistance

Plans should include children, older adults, people living alone, people with limited mobility, hearing or vision difficulties, cognitive or emotional needs, essential medications, medical equipment, service animals, or transportation needs.

☐ Ask the person what help is useful rather than deciding for them.

☐ Assign a primary check-in person and a backup.

☐ Confirm communication methods, medication, equipment, power, and evacuation needs.

☐ Record only necessary private information and protect it.

HAZARDOUS WORK SHOULD NOT BE SOLITARY

Use a buddy system

PERSON ONE

Performs the task

Works within training and stays focused on the job.

PERSON TWO

Watches and assists

Monitors hazards, maintains communication, and gets help if needed.

Use buddies for cutting wood, moving heavy objects, severe-weather work, checking damaged areas, and other difficult tasks. A buddy system does not make an unsafe structure or untrained operation safe.

Keep information clear

Known

Facts confirmed by direct observation or a reliable source.

Unknown

Questions that remain unanswered.

Next

The immediate action or decision.

Owner

The person responsible for following up.

Date and time every notice. Clearly correct outdated or false information instead of letting multiple versions circulate.

Hold short briefings

1. What has changed?
2. What is the most urgent need?
3. Who is doing what, with which backup?
4. Which supplies are running low?
5. What safety issue must everyone know?
6. When and where is the next update?

Keep operational meetings brief. Record decisions and assign a person to communicate them to anyone absent.

FAIRNESS REQUIRES VISIBILITY

Track essential resources

RESOURCE	AMOUNT NOW	USE PER DAY	RECHECK
Drinking water			
Food			
Heating fuel			
Batteries			
Medical supplies			

Prioritize life and health. Explain rationing rules, review them as conditions change, and do not let a few people use supplies without recording what remains.

A PERSON SEEKING HELP MAY ALSO HELP

Accept help safely

Ask new arrivals what they can do, what support they need, and whether they have relevant training. Verify credentials when a task carries medical, electrical, structural, or other serious risk.

Give new helpers a clear task, a partner, boundaries, needed protection, and a check-in time. Do not assign dangerous work merely because someone volunteers.

Know limits and manage conflict

Know how many people can be sheltered, how much safe water and food remain, what sanitation capacity exists, and which medical needs can be handled safely. Seek outside assistance early when needs exceed capacity.

Stress can make people impatient, afraid, angry, or confused. Keep disagreements focused on the immediate problem, use the agreed facts and rules, and ask: **What needs to happen now?**

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple community kit

☐ Written skills roster

☐ Emergency contact list

☐ Household or resident list

☐ Notebook and clipboard

☐ Pens and permanent markers

☐ Printed emergency procedures

☐ Local maps

☐ Role-assignment sheets

☐ Backup list

☐ Accountability sheet

☐ Supply-tracking sheets

☐ Dated notice-board paper

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Expect one person to manage everything.

✗ Depend on one person for an essential skill.

✗ Assume everyone knows the plan.

✗ Forget people with additional support needs.

✗ Allow rumors to replace verified information.

✗ Use essential supplies without tracking them.

✗ Assign hazardous jobs beyond someone's training.

✗ Ignore exhaustion or growing conflict.

✗ Wait until an emergency to learn what people know.

TRY THIS NOW

People practice

Gather the household, group, or participating neighbors and ask: **What could you help with if normal services stopped?**

1. Complete the skills roster and note training limits.
2. Name a lead and backup for six essential roles.
3. Identify people who have requested extra assistance.
4. Choose a reliable information point and update schedule.
5. Practice one five-minute briefing.
6. Identify the most important skill with no backup.

Arrange training or cross-training for the missing skill.

Quick checklist

☐ I know what useful skills participating people have.

☐ Essential roles have trained backup people.

☐ Responsibilities can be divided without overloading one person.

☐ Primary and backup helpers will check people needing support.

☐ We have one place for verified, dated information.

☐ We can track essential supplies and daily use.

☐ We know who coordinates each task.

☐ We understand our limits and when to seek outside help.

☐ Important knowledge is written down and shared appropriately.

REMEMBER

One person does not need to know everything.

Knowledge becomes stronger when it is shared.

A calm, organized group can solve problems one person cannot.

SHARE SKILLS. SHARE WORK. HELP ONE ANOTHER.

Official guidance and training

Connect local plans with emergency management, trained responders, and established volunteer organizations.

FEMA: Community Emergency Response Team
Basic Training

(https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2019.CERT_.Basic_.PM_FINAL_508c.pdf)

Ready.gov: Make a Household Plan(<https://www.ready.gov/plan>)

FEMA: Individuals and Communities(<https://www.fema.gov/emergency-managers/individuals-communities>)

CDC: Get Involved in Community Preparedness(<https://www.cdc.gov/prepare-your-health/create-community/get-involved.html>)

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Practice

Do It Before You Need It.

Reading gives you information. Safe, repeated practice shows whether your supplies, instructions, and skills actually work before stress, darkness, or disrupted utilities make every task harder.

PRACTICE TURNS KNOWLEDGE INTO ABILITY.

START TODAY

Run one small, safe drill

1

Choose one task with a clear objective, such as finding every flashlight or cooking one stored meal.

2

Gather the people and supplies involved. Explain what is simulated and what remains normal.

3

Do the task using only the equipment and written instructions you expect to have.

4

Record what worked, what failed, what was missing, and who will correct each gap.

STOP RULE

End the drill if conditions become unsafe. Never disable smoke or carbon-monoxide alarms, essential medical equipment, medication refrigeration, emergency communications, or

necessary utilities merely to make a drill feel realistic. Do not create real fire, electrical, structural, or sanitation hazards.

BUILD CONFIDENCE GRADUALLY

One skill, one objective, one improvement

You do not need a dramatic survival exercise. Begin with a short task that can be completed safely, then increase complexity only after the basics work.

Choose → Do → Observe → Improve

☐ **Choose:** Name exactly what you want to prove.

☐ **Do:** Use the real supplies, people, and written instructions.

☐ **Observe:** Note time, fuel, water, missing items, confusion, and safety concerns.

☐ **Improve:** Assign a person and date for every correction.

Practice the essential systems

WATER

Make safe water

Do: Find containers, clarify cloudy water if needed, use your planned treatment method, cool it safely, store it cleanly, and label it. **Record:** treatment time, fuel used, yield, and whether you could do it without grid power.

FOOD

Cook one outage meal

Do: Prepare familiar stored food without the electric stove, refrigerator, or a store trip. **Record:** water, fuel, preparation time, portions, satisfaction, and missing tools.

SPROUTING

Grow a small batch

Do: Sprout lentils or mung beans with clean equipment and safe water. **Record:** seed amount, rinsing schedule, days to harvest, water used, yield, smell, texture, and whether the batch remained clean.

SANITATION

Set up, but do not use

Do: Line the toilet or bucket with a strong bag, stage absorbent and paper, choose a protected waste location, and make a handwashing station. **Record:** setup time and missing hygiene supplies.

FIRE AND HEAT

Operate the approved system

Do: Outdoors or in an approved, properly vented installation, practice startup, control, shutdown, and boiling a large pot of water. **Check:** fuel, clearances, ventilation, alarms, and extinguisher. Never improvise indoor combustion.

TOOLS

Complete a small task

Do: Use a hand saw, hammer, shovel, adjustable wrench, or another expected tool for an ordinary task. **Record:** condition, sharpness, protective equipment, effort, maintenance needed, and storage location.

FIRST AID

COMMUNICATION

Open and use the kit

Do: Find gloves, gauze, bandages, tape, cold packs, and medicines; practice a simple bandage on an uninjured volunteer. **Check:** dates, medication lists, training, and the nearest AED. Use training equipment for advanced procedures.

Work without internet

Do: Turn off Wi-Fi on one device, find the radio, tune a known station, use a printed contact list, and review meeting places and the out-of-area contact. **Record:** battery condition and information missing from paper copies.

COMBINE THE BASICS

Try a short power-outage period

For a few planned hours, avoid nonessential conveniences such as main lights, the electric stove, television, and home internet. Keep essential systems available and tell everyone when the exercise starts and ends.

SEE

Use staged flashlights, headlamps, or lanterns and move safely.

EAT

Prepare one simple stored meal with the approved backup method.

COMMUNICATE

Use printed contacts, radio, and the household meeting plan.

CONSERVE

Track battery, fuel, and water use instead of guessing.

Keep it safe: Do not disconnect refrigerators holding essential medicines or food that cannot safely warm, medical devices, alarms, sump pumps, heating needed for life safety, or any system whose interruption could cause damage.

SHARE THE KNOWLEDGE

Practice with other people

One person should not be the only one who knows how to treat water, operate approved equipment, find supplies, shut off water, or contact help. Let each person perform an age- and ability-appropriate task while another person observes.

PRIMARY

Does the task

Uses the equipment and explains each step.

BACKUP

Repeats the task

Uses the written instructions and identifies unclear steps.

Run a five-minute after-action review

Worked

What should remain unchanged?

Didn't

What failed, confused people, or took too long?

Missing

What supply, skill, instruction, or backup was absent?

Owner

Who will correct each gap?

Due

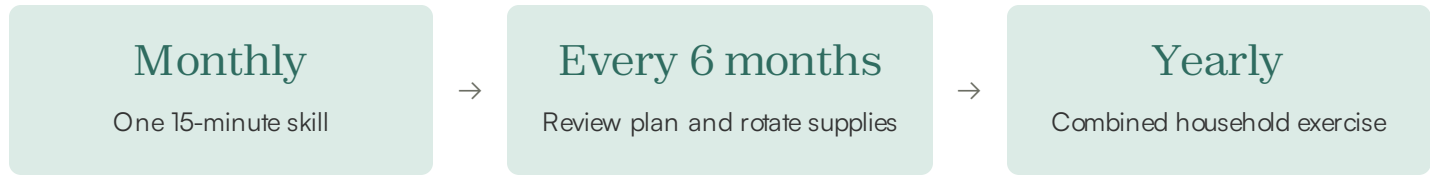
When will it be fixed and retested?

FINDING	CORRECTION	OWNER	DUE / RETEST

Write observations while they are fresh: dead batteries, missing wrench, excessive fuel use, unclear labels, difficult instructions, or food that required too much water.

MAKE PRACTICE ROUTINE

Use a simple repeating schedule



Also retest after moving, changing equipment, adding a household member or pet, developing a new medical need, or finding a problem during an actual outage.

SKILLS TO DEMONSTRATE

Simple practice list

☐ Purify or disinfect water correctly

☐ Boil water without grid power

☐ Cook one emergency meal

☐ Sprout a small batch of seed

☐ Set up an emergency toilet

☐ Create a handwashing station

☐ Operate an approved heat or cooking system

☐ Use basic hand tools safely

☐ Locate and use the first-aid kit

☐ Find emergency lights in the dark

☐ Charge an essential device

☐ Tune the emergency radio

☐ Locate water, electrical, and fuel shutoffs

☐ Practice the meeting and contact plan

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

- ✗ Buy equipment and never operate or maintain it.
- ✗ Store food you have never prepared with the backup method.
- ✗ Assume every household member knows the plan.
- ✗ Make the drill hazardous to make it feel realistic.
- ✗ Test too many systems at once before mastering the basics.
- ✗ Depend entirely on instructions stored online.
- ✗ Ignore accessibility, medical, child, elder, or pet needs.
- ✗ Notice a failure but never assign or verify the correction.
- ✗ Make practice so complicated that no one repeats it.

TRY THIS NOW

The one-hour challenge

Simulate loss of electricity and running water without actually disabling anything essential or unsafe.

1. Find working emergency lighting.
2. Find and measure available drinking water.
3. Identify the approved backup cooking method and fuel.
4. Set up the emergency toilet and handwashing station without using them.
5. Open the first-aid kit and locate bleeding-control supplies.
6. Find, power, and tune the radio.
7. Locate the most important hand tools and utility shutoffs.
8. Write down every missing, expired, unclear, or inaccessible item.

Choose the most important gap, correct it, and repeat that part of the drill.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have actually treated water with my planned method.

☐ I have cooked a meal with my approved backup system.

☐ I have successfully sprouted seed.

☐ I can set up emergency sanitation and handwashing.

☐ I have used and maintained my basic hand tools.

☐ I know what is in the first-aid kit and where it is.

☐ I have tested flashlights, radios, batteries, and charging options.

☐ I can locate important shutoffs without searching online.

☐ Other people know the plan and can perform essential tasks.

☐ We record, assign, correct, and retest problems found in practice.

REMEMBER

What you read can be forgotten.

What you practice becomes familiar.

What becomes familiar is easier to do under stress.

LEARN IT. DO IT. KNOW YOU CAN DO IT.

Official planning and practice resources

Use local emergency guidance and task-specific training when designing household or community exercises.

Ready.gov: Make a Household Plan(<https://www.ready.gov/plan>)

Ready.gov: Are You Ready? In-Depth Guide(<https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2021-11/are-you-ready-guide.pdf>)

Ready.gov: Low and No Cost Preparedness(<https://www.ready.gov/low-and-no-cost>)

FEMA: Preparedness Activities and Webinars (<https://www.fema.gov/emergency-managers/individuals-communities/preparedness-activities-research-webinars>)
